because of the distaste with which its luminaries look upon matters to do with religion.'[164] The same can be said about the wider left-wing Indian women's movement and how it approached the BJP and the RSS.

Even as the feminist movement remained deeply engaged in vociferous debates on identity and patriarchy, the evidence in this chapter shows that the BJP significantly widened its ambit and drastically increased its gender mobilisation. I am not a specialist on women's issues. However, as someone examining the BJP's growth and looking into this arena from that vantage point, I was surprised that I found virtually no serious research from gender scholars on the BJP and its mobilisation of women in the post-2000 period. While a number of scholars did fine studies of the Hindi nationalist movement and the woman question in the 1990s, there has been no substantial work since. This is a surprising gap because women have been at the centre of the BJP's rise as India's predominant political party after 2014. Their modes of mobilisation and the impact of governmental polices obviously needs new research that gender theorists and activists must engage with and examine more deeply. In some ways, the BJP's rise under Modi embodies a clash of different versions of feminism. Simply rejecting its ideas on women as regressive is not enough. Even those who oppose it must try and understand why more Indian women agree with the BJP's notion of women's equality than theirs. It necessitates a fresh interrogation of old assumptions and a new debate on women and Indian politics. If this chapter can provoke such debates and more research into how operates, I would consider its work done.

At the time of writing, the BJP was initiating another gender-initiative to bring the minimum legally acceptable marriage age of Indian women on par with men to twenty-one, from eighteen years of age. Announcing that he had been getting 'a lot of letters from aware daughters from across the country for an early decision on the matter', Prime Minister Modi declared in October 2020 that his government would decide soon after a high-powered committee headed by Jaya Jaitly, former president of the Samata Party, gave its report. Like the triple talaq case before it, the proposal was opposed by several women's rights groups on various technical grounds